

Site B, Student Interview 1

[0:00:00.0] **Interviewer:** Okay. Okay. So just kind of to jog your memory here, do you remember kind of this, this lecture, the coding and analyzing qualitative data? Does this look kind of familiar?

Jonny: mhm.

Interviewer: Okay, cool. So our first question is very general. How did the lessons and discussions around data analysis go for you? Like, what were your experiences like or anything that comes to mind?

Jonny: Um I think they [0:00:30.0] went well. I think I would say it's more neutral. I don't really feel swayed in one particular direction. I think a lot of, a lot of what we were talking about I had already been exposed to, right, like, you know, in a graduate program and not read articles or see things and then hear conversations about, like data analysis. I think it was interesting to sort of get the, the deeper detail of qualitative analysis. [0:01:00.0] But even then I think the book, the book that we were using by Merriam and Teasdale. That alongside some other sources kind of, it was almost was like [Site B Instructor] PowerPoint and the information that we had in class or supplemental to what we had already read or what we were already learning. And my guess is that it's because it was an intro qualitative course so we didn't necessarily get into the weeds of, you know, here' [0:01:30.0] s how you code for patterns or here's how you code for this or that. So I think it, again, very neutral. You know, wasn't really I don't really feel one major way over the other. But like I said, I think it was helpful information that was supplemental to what we were consuming and what we had already or what I had already consumed throughout other means.

Interviewer: Great. So, so when you say like [0:02:00.0] qualitative data analysis and you're talking about qualitative data analysis, what does that mean to you?

Jonny: So I think of it and my thoughts here are very much influenced by [Site B Instructor] course, and things like that, but I really think of it as this sort of just spending some time, really looking through, thinking about you know the verbal themes that have been said by participants. And so it's just looking for connections between the different [0:02:30.0] things that an individual is saying right at different times. There may be patterns or threads of understanding between different transcripts of information. You could also be thinking about that in terms of different people, right? So if you're looking for themes or categories, it's like so taking all of these themes that have been said, transcribed and written, you know, putting those things together to really figure out what they mean. And I think it changes [0:03:00.0] depending on what the research is and what the principal topic of the study is and all that, but

I think it's important to sort of think about how all of those different pieces from different people at different time, right? How are those different components of what has been said kind of come together to tell some sort of a story or some sort of narrative about what's happening or what's going on, or how people [0:03:30.0] feel. And again, you know, specific questions related to whatever is being studied.

Interviewer: Yeah. So earlier you used the language, coding. Coding patterns. And I'm wondering if you might talk to me a little bit about how you think about coding and what coding qualitatively means to you?

Jonny: Yeah. So to me, coding I think is the more individual piece of that qualitative data says. I think that's where the researcher really has the opportunity [0:04:00.0] to kinda get into the data. And so but those codes that are kind of being created are really sort of flowing from the researcher. I think they're influenced by what the researcher is reading, but it is really (inaudible) the researchers sort of determining, or trying to determine what is important and what's not important. So those codes are sort of the internal manifestations of what that researcher thinks is important. So it is a process [0:04:30.0] of determining what's important, and what's not important. And in really a balancing act between what the researcher's thinking and what the participants are saying.

Interviewer: Mmm. So how would you distinguish or would you distinguish like this idea of coding, and then you use like the language, themes and categorization. Can you talk to me a bit about how you understand the differences between the two of those things?

Jonny: Yeah. So I think codes [0:05:00.0] are sort of the initial sets of words or phrases or things that, that are there. And, you know, every code is not necessarily going to lead to a category or to a theme. There will certainly be some code because of that balancing act that's happening, the researcher my, 'oh, I think this is important', but in relationship to other codes from other transcripts. It may it may be that that code from this transcript these couple codes [0:05:30.0] are these couple of phrases or things that I thought were important are actually not important to the research as a whole. It may just be a one-off thing that's important to the individual, or it could be just a reflection of whatever, wherever the researcher was. When they were conducting that research. It's like oh I thought this was important but it didn't really come up anywhere else, so maybe that was me, or the [0:06:00.0] researcher sort of buying into... the researcher was buying into that or reflecting their biases or perspectives. But I think codes or sort of the precursor to the themes and the categories. And all of the codes that may arise in the study will not necessarily lead to a theme or a category.

Interviewer: Awesome, great. So you also talked briefly about you know this was kind of an introductory course, so it's like a broad overview of [0:06:30.0] a lot of different topics. So thinking about qualitative data analysis, what approaches to qualitative data analysis did you learn or think about, if any?

Jonny: So I think we did. There were four or five big ones. Ethnography, grounded theory, and now I'm blanking on the rest of them.

Interviewer: That is okay. I don't even know if I would have gotten two so.

Jonny: But um and it's funny because I um, grounded theory, [0:07:00.0] there is one that is very similar to grounded theory and I can't remember what it was called because I remember asking questions about it because it was just so, you know it was just like like, what's the difference between these two things? And it was such a minute difference that it was like, oh, in this process, I think one was more inductive than the other ones. So you don't start with the literature or [0:07:30.0] something like that, but I think obviously if I had the the PowerPoint and the text and everything in front of me, I could tell you what those differences are among those different approaches. But I do recall us sort of talking about four or five approaches to it. Getting into the, again, the very hierarchical, broad overview of what those approaches are. But again, because it was an intro course, didn't really get into the specificity of [0:08:00.0] this is why grounded theory is grounded theory and we certainly weren't reading. You know I think it's Strauss and... Glaser and Strauss or someone that that's behind. We weren't reading any of those people. So again, very, very high level overview of those different approaches. And my guess is that that was because intro course, you know as you develop, as folks develop research, they will do lit reviews and they will discover all [0:08:30.0] of those different pieces of the puzzle um a little later.

Interviewer: Great. So what were some of the things that you've found especially helpful during the lessons and discussions around analyzing your data, analyzing qualitative data?

Jonny: Yeah, I think the most productive and the most helpful thing that we did in [Site B Instructor] course was coming like using class time as a lab. So we would, we were asked to do interviews and we were asked to [0:09:00.0] code that data. And really having an opportunity to do that in class and have that practical experience of the whole collecting the data, working with our own data. Prior to that, [Site B Instructor] had sort of given us some one of her transcripts and we were transcribing, coding and analyzing. I think those practical experiences are really important when it comes to data analysis because I think we all, we can all read and talk about lots of different things, [0:09:30.0] but qualitative research, is not like quantitative research, right? It's, you know, when you, when you think think quant you are very much like, Oh, I'm in a computer lab, i'm in R or I'm in SPSS. Like there, i'm I'm physically doing something to get the results. Whereas Qualitative data tends to be more manual. Right, like there is no computer program that will exist, that will analyze the data for you. [0:10:00.0] The programs will help you organize your data, but it won't do the analysis for you. So I really think the space and time that was made available for those particular lab, the what I call the lab pieces those were really helpful because it really gave us an opportunity to sort of fine tune our approach. I think [Site B Instructor] had sort of talked about the use of

computer programs, but because of that experience, I find it [0:10:30.0] more helpful to do it manually. Like I can read my transcript quicker and faster and I can highlight things and I can write up and down the document in that makes more sense to me than it.. and it's quicker than spending five hours trying to set everything up in a computer program.

Interviewer: Yeah, totally. So I'm going to share my computer screen again, and I'm just wondering if you remember this exercise that [0:11:00.0] you all did with [daughter] and her dad? And then there was like, I think it was two sheets of paper. So like that was the first one and then you guys got like columns and rows. Do you remember this exercise?

Jonny: Mhm.

Interviewer: Can you talk to me a little bit about how that exercise went for you?

Jonny: Yeah. I think this was one of the one of the lab experiments that I referenced previously. I [0:11:30.0] think this was exactly that. And I think it was a cool first take at practicing coding and analysis. I remember the assignment being a bit difficult just because we didn't really have the context, my classmates and I, we didn't really have the context for what [Site B Instructor] study was, so we were just reading this transcript, and we weren't really sure what to make of it, right? Like we like like like [Site B Instructor] were your research [0:12:00.0] question? Like what, like what are we trying to get out of this? Like and we didn't really have any kind of context about the research that [Site B Instructor] does in any capacity. So in a certain way it was like, here's this random thing. Analyze it and code it. And I mean, I think the experience was helpful in certain ways, but it would have been more helpful if we had had some of that context about [0:12:30.0] like okay, like this is what the research questions were. This was sort of like a broad, like the abstract of the study or something like this. Just something that would give you a bit more context about what we were supposed to be looking for, because you know in any kind of qualitative study, you'll have research questions and you'll have some sort of, you'll have a guiding framework for what to look for. And [0:13:00.0] if you don't have that, you're just looking at words on paper and they don't really mean anything, right? Like I can I can create some codes for this transcript you gave me, sure. But I won't really know whether these are good codes or not or whether they're useful or helpful if I don't have a research question. Or if I don't have some sort of background about what you were [0:13:30.0] interested in trying to find out about it. And It's difficult to sort of create that in the moment with a random document that you yourself didn't produce or with subjects that you don't know.

Interviewer: Great, and sorry about my dog if you heard him barking. So [Site B Instructor] also asked you all to watch a film. And I know that you all watched a couple of films in the class. So the one I'm specifically [0:14:00.0] referring to, I think it was a Jewish family and or a Jewish woman and she became like sicker and sicker. Like it was--

Jonny: Oh yeah yeah yeah they were out in California.

Interviewer: Yeah. Can you tell me a little bit about how you thought about that film specifically related to learning about qualitative data analysis?

Jonny: Yeah. I think her was Meyerhof. Barbara Meyerhof, was the woman and I think we were talking about ethnography. And [0:14:30.0] the film kind of came about sort of from this, this notion that the researcher like the individual is the instrument. And so we sort of used that video as a way to sort of think about what it means to really be integrated into a community, to really get rich data in using that long-term exposure in the field as a, as a point of validation for any kind of results or data that popped up. I think [0:15:00.0] we got a lot of that out of that, but I don't know that the concept was misunderstood or kinda miss characterized by folks. So I kind of didn't understand the full point or purpose of showing the video, because I think after about 20, 30 minutes, it became very clear that Barbra or Meyerhof, the woman in the video, had very much been integrated into, into the community. So no one was questioning that. So I [0:15:30.0] saw it, and I I think it was fine, but it was one of those things just not necessarily understanding like what's the central point here? And we watched the whole thing and it was probably an hour and a half, two hours. Like I think we split it into two days actually and we watched the whole thing. But it was like I dont know it just didn't feel like the best use of time. Because I [0:16:00.0] think what we were supposed to take away from it we all got after about 30 minutes of watching it.

Interviewer: Uh-huh. Did you, do you recall if she asked you to take notes of anything? Or did you find yourself taking notes of anything in particular?

Jonny: Um I didn't really take notes on anything in particular. I think [Site B Instructor] kind of asked us to, to just be mindful of things. But that film in particular wasn't [0:16:30.0] one that we were talking about extensively. There were some others where it was very clear like, hey, take some notes and talk about themes that emerge. But for that one in particular, there was just nothing. Nothing that stood out that I recall. There was nothing about what she shared with us that stood out. And I don't recall writing anything down. It was more so like I said, it was one of those things where [0:17:00.0] we showed, watched a movie, and briefly kinda did a reflection on it. But the reflection sort of reveal like yeah, okay, like this is what it means when the researchers the instrument. They're in the community, they're highly involved and engaged. Yeah, and again, just didn't feel like it was worthwhile to to watch the whole thing.

Interviewer: Totally. Yep. So I.. this is my favorite question in the interview protocol just because I feel [0:17:30.0] like as graduate students we have so much to offer. And so I'm just

wondering if you might share what suggestions you might have for an instructor who's teaching qualitative data analysis in the future.

Jonny: Yeah! Um I think um there's a couple things. The first one, I think if, if students are following the sequence, I think there's [research methodology course A], there's [research methodology course B], everybody in the class that I was in had taken one, one [0:18:00.0] of those two courses. Um [Site B Instructor] taught [research methodology course B]. I took [research methodology course A] and so people will come to [Introduction to Qualitative Research] or my guess is that people will come to [Introduction to Qualitative Research] with some basic understandings of what qualitative research is and maybe even with some idea about what those you know foundational approaches are, right? Like I like I said, I got to [Introduction to Qualitative Research] and was like okay, I know what research is. I know broadly about qualitative research and so I [0:18:30.0] don't know, I think it may make more sense, um, and this is number two, I think it makes more sense to really take that intro to qualitative study the course and spend more time really getting into those approaches. um and really talking about like, what does it mean to do an ethnographic study? What does it mean to do a grounded theory. Like like really spending some time getting into those topics. And then more exposure [0:19:00.0] or exposing students to more of the literature that is coming out of inquiry methodology, from a qualitative data perspective. I think the texts that we used, Merriam and Teasdale was a good text. I also really enjoyed the dance book that we read. But some of those other supplemental pieces, it was, you know, like I think [Site B Instructor] was trying to provide examples of good qualitative studies, but in doing that, there was a lack of really preparing [0:19:30.0] us to do qualitative research, if that makes sense. It was like, here's an example of, of this thing. And the examples were all very dated. We're reading like Jane Addams pieces from the 18th century, 19th century, like all very data pieces. Whereas more specific studies or more texts on, like had we read Glaser and Strauss. Like, like as we talk about grounded theory or as we talk about ethnography, here's literature on how [0:20:00.0] to actually do an ethnographic study. Here's some, here's some pieces on what that means from a critical perspective. I think that, and I think the outcomes for that would lead...More people would leave class feeling like they learned something new. And that's not to say that I didn't learn anything. I just, I wrapped up the class and, and, you know, learned how to code data or had some experience coding the data. Excuse [0:20:30.0] me. But it was one of those courses that was like, like you really, really didn't have to show up to class to be successful. And I think it would have been more helpful if we were reading actual like, like inquiry method- Llike here's grounded theory. here's ethnography, here is um narrative inquiry like-

Interviewer: Like examples.

Jonny: Yeah, more current examples that are like grounded in empirical studies. But also more of the theoretical [0:21:00.0] pieces behind, like yes this is ethnography. This is why ethnography is ethnography. Here are a few studies that will help you if you choose to do an ethnographic study. Here are some resources or tools for you if you choose to do a grounded theory study. Instead of giving us what felt, in my opinion, what felt like a replication of a

module from a previous course. So you take a module, you take one of the qualitative [0:21:30.0] inquiry module from [research methodology course A] or [research methodology course B], and that may be a week out of a separate 16 week course. You take that module and then you stretch it out to 16 weeks or 13 weeks, or whatever it was. And it's just like like most people in the room, even if they hadn't taken [research methodology course A] or [research methodology course B] probably could have figured out what qualitative research was and what the, what the methods were. It's like Google, [0:22:00.0] hey Google, what are the five common approaches to qualitative research?

Interviewer: Yeah. So I see that we have two minutes left. So before I let you go, I just want to make sure is there anything else that you want to share with me about qualitative data analysis, anything that you feel like you are excited to talk about and you didn't get to talk about?

Jonny: Um no, I don't think anything comes up.

Interviewer: Well, [0:22:30.0] thank you so much. I mean, I learned so much actually. This was a really generative interview. So thank you for sharing with me and thank you so much for your time again. I hope that you have a good rest of your summer and your internship goes Well.

Jonny: Thank you so much, [interviewer]. I'll talk to you later.

Interviewer: Yeah, I'll talk to you later. Bye. Bye.